

Trophy

Mullin Survives the Sixteenth

A three-time Wooden Spoon holder turned Trophy champion held off a grandstand finish from Alex Baker, whose charge was undone by the same nightmare hole that had wrecked his tournament three rounds earlier.

David Mullin won the TEG 14 Trophy with 154 points, two clear of Alex Baker. It is the third-best of his own career, and very nearly all of it was banked before anyone thought to object.

The foundation was laid on the first two links. At Royal Cinque Ports he went round in 87, seven strokes better than his previous visit. The engine room was a four-hole run from the 9th: par, birdie at the 10th, then two more pars, 13 points, a man briefly playing golf on purpose. The sequence ended at the 13th with a double bogey. At Littlestone he shot 85, again seven better than last time out, and another course best.

Prince's declined to co-operate. In round three he arrived at the par-five 8th with a

tournament in his pocket and took nine. A quadruple bogey. It returned nothing, which is the standard yield on a nine. He then took 13 points from the closing four holes, three pars and a birdie at the last, as though the 8th had happened to a stranger. Round four produced another quadruple bogey, an eight at the 10th. Two quads on the same links in two days. The trophy did not appear to mind.

That opened the door for Alex Baker, who had trailed by as many as nine. He answered with 10 points across the first three holes of the final round and 11 more from the 13th to the 15th, closing to within two. Then he reached the 16th and made a ten. His four days had begun to come apart considerably earlier, at Littlestone, where he dropped 12 shots across holes 2 to 5.

AT A GLANCE
Trophy Winner David Mullin (3rd Trophy) Runner-up: Alex Baker
Green Jacket David Mullin (9th Jacket) Runner-up: Jon Baker
Wooden Spoon Jon Baker (1st Spoon) Next above: Gregg Williams

FINAL · Trophy
DM 154 | AB 152 | GW 137 | JB 125
FINAL · Green Jacket
DM +68 | JB +75 | GW +76 | AB +102

Green Jacket | David Mullin

Twelve Down to Seven, Never in Doubt

David Mullin's gross lead shrank by five shots in the final round alone, but the Green Jacket was never seriously threatened.

David Mullin took the Green Jacket at TEG 14 with a gross total of +68, seven clear of Jon Baker. His ninth.

The number was built on consistency across Kent's four links rounds. Mullin set a personal best on every course he played: 87 at Royal Cinque Ports and 85 at Littlestone, each seven strokes better than his previous visit in TEG 13, and 91 at Prince's Shore/Dunes, one better than before.

None of those figures would trouble a club noticeboard in isolation. Stacked together, they were unanswerable.

Behind him the chase was real, and late. Jon Baker trailed by 15 at one point and closed to seven, the bulk of that work arriving in the final round at Prince's, where his 83 gross set a new course record. The previous mark of 85 had stood across five prior visits, and was Jon Baker's own. Gregg

Williams made up more ground still, trailing by 18 at his worst and finishing eight back. His +76 is a personal-best Green Jacket gross total, and his 86 at Prince's in round three was a course best for him too.

The gap never closed far enough. Mullin's margin of seven at the finish flatters the field, given how much larger it had been for most of the four days.

Wooden Spoon | Jon Baker

Twelve Shots Adrift, No Argument

Jon Baker was worst in the field in two separate rounds, and the final one came a day too late to change anything.

Jon Baker finished last in the Stableford count and took the TEG 14 Wooden Spoon with 125 points across the four rounds. The defence of a title can take many forms. He chose this one, and won it by 12, which is a margin of some authority.

The early links did him no favours, and he returned the courtesy. At Royal Cinque Ports his best gross was 92, seven strokes worse than the 85 he had managed on his previous visit. At Littlestone he posted 92 against a prior best of 79. Thirteen shots is not a bad day; it is a change of identity. His third round at Prince's brought 28 points, held down in part by a run of pars from the 14th that ended with a triple bogey six at the par-three 17th.

The final round was another man entirely. Jon Baker returned 39 points, an improvement of 11 on the previous day, and his 83 gross set a new course record for Prince's Shore/Dunes, beating the previous mark of 85 that had stood across five prior visits. It was also his personal best on the layout, two strokes better than his last time there. The scoring came in a burst: five holes without dropping a gross shot from the 11th to the 15th, back-to-back birdies at the 12th and 13th, a two-hole birdie streak that equals the all-time TEG record, and 14 points across holes 12 to 15.

Then the 16th, which had already relieved Alex Baker of the Trophy that afternoon, took a double bogey from Jon and ended the run. He ran up an eight at the 18th. He therefore holds the course record and the Wooden Spoon at the same time, which takes some arranging.

Alex Baker

The Sixteenth Strikes Twice

Two different courses, the same hole number, and the same catastrophic 10 — bookending a tournament Alex Baker otherwise nearly won.

Two of Alex Baker's four rounds in Kent ended with a 10 on the card, and on both occasions the number arrived at a hole numbered 16. Different courses, different pars, no connection whatsoever beyond the obvious one. The first came in the opening round at Royal Cinque Ports, a quintuple bogey at the par-five 16th, stroke index 7, no Stableford points. The second, at Prince's on the Sunday, was worse in relative terms: a 10 at a par four, a sextuple bogey, on stroke index 17, the second-easiest hole on the card. Taking ten shots there requires a degree of commitment.

The Prince's 10 was the more painful for what preceded it. Alex Baker had played the 13th, 14th and 15th in par, par, par, three holes without dropping a gross shot, worth eleven Stableford points. The 16th erased the lot at a stroke. He was not alone in losing his footing there. Jon Baker arrived at the same hole having gone par-birdie-birdie-par-par from the 11th, and made a double bogey for no points.

These were the headline numbers, not the only ones. Alex Baker also had an 8 at the 11th at Royal Cinque Ports, a 9 at the 5th and an 8 at the 8th at Littlestone, and an 8 at the 10th at Prince's in round three. Five further holes returning nothing. His round-one 98 at Royal Cinque Ports was still four strokes better than his previous visit, which tells you a good deal about the previous visit.

Gregg Williams

Williams's Best Week, Nobody Noticed

An 18-shot deficit after a blown-up third hole didn't stop Gregg Williams closing hard and posting his best-ever TEG gross total.

Williams finished TEG 14 with a Gross total of +76, a personal best, and no prize of any description. The number rested on two course records of his own: 93 at Royal Cinque Ports, one better than his previous mark there of 94, and 86 at Prince's in round three, three strokes better than his last visit and inside his previous best of 89.

It was not tidy. He opened at Deal with a 9 at the par-five 3rd, stroke index 4, a quadruple bogey worth nothing at all. Littlestone was worse in the wider sense: 97, eleven strokes adrift of the 86 he had managed there before, and only 27 Stableford points.

Round three was the correction. He gained twelve points on the day, reaching 39, and the middle of it was genuinely solid: pars at the 9th, 10th and 11th for nine points, three holes without dropping a gross shot, then two more clean holes at the 15th and 16th. Between those came an 8 at the par-five 12th, which brought the exhibition to a close.

Sunday offered more steadiness in patches, gross pars at the 5th and 6th and again at the 14th and 15th. Having trailed the TEG 14 Green Jacket lead by 18 at one stage, he closed to within 8. Ten shots recovered. Eight still owed.

Records & Personal Bests

Notable achievements: TEG 14

TEG Records

— Jon Baker's 2-hole "Birdies" streak ties the all-time TEG record (2), at T14 R4 H12 to T14 R4 H13